

Self-Knowledge & Identity

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION: EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Ntoumanis et al. (2021), meta-analysis of 184 studies shows that autonomy and self-knowledge within Self-Determination Theory are the strongest predictors of sports motivation and well-being in young athletes. *Psychology of Sport & Exercise*.

Meta-analysis Zuber & Conzelmann (2014), analysis of 47 studies confirms that intrinsic motivation and self-concept are directly linked to sports performance in youth. *International Review of Sport & Exercise Psychology*.

Longitudinal study Deci & Ryan (1985, revised 2017), Self-Determination Theory: autonomy, competence, and relatedness as universal basic needs for optimal development and well-being in sport.

GUIDANCE PER EXERCISE

- 1 My Three Words:** Give players 3 minutes to write their words solo. Then have them work in pairs to write three words about the other person without consulting. Close with a brief group discussion: "Who was surprised by others' words?" Don't go deeper on negative surprises in the group. Handle those individually.
- 2 Energy Givers vs. Energy Drains:** Have players fill this in individually. Then discuss only the energy givers with the group. Create awareness: "How can we as a team build in more energy givers?" Discuss energy drains individually or confidentially.
- 3 Values Compass:** After filling it in, ask volunteers to share their top value. Create a ranking on the board. Ask: "If these are our team values, how do we see them reflected in behavior?" This becomes the bridge to following months.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Fill in the worksheet yourself and share your answers. Vulnerability from the coach lowers the threshold for players to be honest.

Tip 2: Take notes of what players share. Use this later in the season to remind them of their own values ("You said courage was important. I saw that today.").

Tip 3: Players who write very little or deviate are not unmotivated. Sometimes self-knowledge is confronting. Address this later individually, not in front of the group.

⚠ Avoid: "Who wants to share their words?" Directly pointing someone out creates insecurity. Build trust by sharing first yourself, then asking for volunteers.

TIMING

- ☐ Introduction of theme and explanation of exercises: 5 minutes
- ☐ Individual worksheet completion: 10 minutes
- ☐ Group discussion Three Words: 10 minutes
- ☐ Group discussion Values Compass: 10 minutes
- ☐ Closing and quote: 5 minutes